

After the Story: The Lever and the Law

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A companion study to *The Palmerton Switch*

Back to the Dead Mountain

Go back with me to Palmerton on the last Friday of January 1985. Snow is falling straight down because there is no wind. Above the zinc works the north face of Blue Mountain is bare of every tree, killed by seventy years of smelter smoke, and under the snow it has turned into the best sledding hill in Carbon County. Annie Sabol is sixteen and hauling her ten-year-old brother Danny up that slope on a Flexible Flyer because their mother told her to.

Then twelve black tank cars full of sulfuric acid roll off the upper siding with no engine and no brakeman, and they drop onto the long grade toward town. The varsity game has just let out. Half the parents in Palmerton are sitting at the crossing below the ballfield with their heaters running.

You remember how it went. Annie and Danny take the steep chute the big kids call the Elevator, racing the runaway cars down the mountain. Danny prays the old Jesus Prayer their grandfather taught them, loud, the way a ten-year-old says the Pledge. Annie steers and keeps her own mouth shut, because she quit praying out loud around eighth grade. At the Palmerton switch the padlock is frozen, the lever is frozen, and the lead car is coming around the curve. Annie runs out of everything she has. So she prays, out loud, words nobody taught her: Jesus, I need more time.

The snow stops in the air. The thunder of the cars stretches into one long note. Danny freezes mid-word with a flake on his eyelashes. A very tall man in a railroad coat comes walking up the track from town carrying a red-globed lantern, and he holds the light on the lock. He never touches the lock and he never touches Annie. Her breath thaws the lock. Her bare hands lift the frozen lever and walk it over, and the iron takes the skin off her palms. The target turns green. The lantern man says one word, "Good," and walks away. Then the snow falls, the cars swing onto the catch track, and twelve acid cars bury themselves in the cinder bank without a single one tipping.

The company men explain it with handbrakes that were never set right. The Allentown paper runs a short piece on page six. And at the kitchen table, with her hands in a dishpan of cool water, Annie's grandfather asks one quiet question: Did he hold the lantern for you?

Tonight we sit with that switch and ask two questions. What do we do with a story where time stops? And why did the lantern man hold the light and leave the lever to a sixteen-year-old girl?

Questions to Sit With

1. Read 2 Kings 20:8-11 and Isaiah 38:7-8, where Hezekiah asks the Lord for a sign and the shadow on the stairway of Ahaz goes back ten steps. Read Joshua 10:12-14, where the sun stands still over Gibeon and the writer says there was no day like it before or after. Annie asked for more time and the snow hung in the air. When Scripture tells you God has bent time before, what does that do to the way you hear Annie's story?
2. Read 2 Kings 6:15-17, where Elisha's servant wakes up to an army around the city and Elisha prays that the young man's eyes would be opened, and the servant sees the hills full of horses and chariots of fire. Read Hebrews 1:14, where angels are called ministering spirits sent out to serve those who will inherit salvation. The lantern man came with light. He did not come with a crowbar. What is the difference between being served and being replaced?
3. Read Philippians 2:12-13, where Paul tells believers to work out their salvation with fear and trembling, because it is God who works in them both to will and to work for His good pleasure. Annie's hands were torn open on the lever, and Dzede told her, "He doesn't throw it for you." Where in your own life are you waiting for heaven to throw a lever that God has put in your hands?

The Teaching: The Lever and the Law

Start where the story starts. With a sled rope, a frozen padlock, an iron lever, and twelve tank cars that weigh more than a church apiece. Everything about that runaway obeys the rules. Steel wheels on cold rail. Gravity pulling a heavy load down a mile of grade. A coupler knocking as the slack comes out. Annie knows those rules because her grandfather drew them for her on the back of a church bulletin, and because she can feel them in her ribs on the way down the Elevator.

That is exactly why the hung snow matters.

John Lennox, the Oxford mathematician, spends a whole chapter of *Can Science Explain Everything?* on the objection most of us have heard from a skeptical friend. Miracles break the laws of nature, the friend says, and now that we know the laws, we know miracles cannot happen. Lennox answers that the laws work the other way around. "When a miracle takes place, it is the laws of nature that alert us to the fact that it is a miracle." (Lennox, ch. 6 Miracles: A Step Too Far?). If Annie did not know how falling snow behaves, she would never have noticed it stop. If Gus Remaley did not know how a frozen switch behaves, he would never have stood there saying, "You threw this. Frozen. By yourself."

Lennox is careful here, and we should be too. "Christians do not deny the laws of nature." (Lennox, ch. 6 Miracles: A Step Too Far?). He calls those laws descriptions of the regular way the Creator built the world to run. The Bible is full of people who knew that dead men stay dead, that seas stay put, that shadows move one direction on a stairway. That is why they were frightened and amazed when those things did otherwise. Lennox makes the point plainly: "The ancient world knew the law of nature as well as we do, that dead bodies do not get up out of graves." (Lennox, ch. 6 Miracles: A Step Too Far?).

Then he gives a picture that fits the switch stand almost too well. "Newton's law of gravitation tells me that if I drop an apple, it will fall towards the centre of the earth. But that law does not prevent someone intervening and catching the apple as it descends." (Lennox, ch. 6 Miracles: A Step Too Far?). The law tells you what happens if nobody steps in. It does not tell you that nobody can step in. The tank cars rolled by the law of gravity. The lever moved by the plain rule of any lever, with a girl's whole weight across it. And for a stretch of time nobody could measure, a hand outside the world caught the falling snow.

Lennox puts the open door in two short sentences. "If one admits the existence of a Creator, the door is inevitably open for that same Creator to intervene in the course of nature." And a few lines later: "Miracles may occur." (Lennox, ch. 6 Miracles: A Step Too Far?). So the real question is whether there is a Creator at all. If there is, the snow over Palmerton is His snow, and He can hold it in the air as easily as Hezekiah's shadow went back ten steps.

Now look at what the story does after the miracle. This is where it gets honest.

The company men say the afternoon crew never set the handbrakes right and the cold let the slack run out. That is a natural explanation, and for the runaway itself it is probably the right one. Lennox quotes Francis Collins, the scientist who led the Human Genome Project, with a warning every believer ought to tape inside a kitchen cabinet: "The only thing that will kill the possibility of miracles more quickly than a committed materialism is the claiming of miracle status for everyday events for which natural explanations are readily at hand." (Francis Collins, quoted in Lennox, ch. 6 *Miracles: A Step Too Far?*). Annie does not go to the newspaper claiming God released the brakes. The brakes were a crew's mistake. The hung snow was the thing no crew could explain. She keeps the two apart, and she keeps the second one close.

And now the lantern man.

He comes walking up the track from town in the held moment, the only thing in the world making a sound. He is huge. He is kind the way a doctor is kind before he sets a bone. And he will not touch the lock. Annie understands it right there on the ballast: the light was for seeing by, the time was the time she asked for, and the hands were hers.

Scripture shows angels doing this kind of work again and again. They bring light into prison cells and open doors, and then Peter has to put on his sandals and walk out (Acts 12:7-10). They stand around Elisha's city so a frightened servant can see he is not alone (2 Kings 6:17). They are ministering spirits sent to serve (Hebrews 1:14). Serving is a different thing from doing your part for you. Dzedo learned that at twenty-two with his hands frozen to the same switch in February of 1951. Annie learns it at sixteen. "He doesn't throw it for you. You know that now."

Paul holds both halves together in one breath when he tells the Philippians to work out their salvation with fear and trembling, because God is the one at work in them to will and to do (Philippians 2:12-13). Annie's prayer and Annie's palms belong in the same sentence. God gave the time. Annie spent it. Neither one happened without the other.

One more thing the story will not let us skip. Annie's first real prayer came from a girl with her mouth against a frozen padlock saying please, far from any church, with none of the monks' old words in it. James reminds us that Elijah was a man with a nature like ours, and he prayed, and the sky answered (James 5:17-18). The prayer that stopped the snow came from a sixteen-year-

old who had been too embarrassed to pray out loud an hour before. That is good news for every one of us who has gone quiet since eighth grade.

Around the Fire: Talk It Over and Take It Home

Talk about the snow. Has there been a night in your life when the ordinary rules bent and you could not explain it? Say it out loud to the people you trust. Then do what Annie did and sort it honestly. Which part has a plain explanation, like the handbrakes? Which part does not? Collins and Lennox will not let us call every coincidence a miracle. They also will not let us pretend God is locked out of His own world.

Talk about the lantern. Where have you been waiting for God to do the work that He has put in your hands? Maybe you have been praying for a broken friendship to fix itself while you avoid the phone call. Maybe you have been praying for a job while the application sits half filled out on the counter. The lantern man held the light. He did not lift the lever. What lever is lying frozen in the ballast at your feet right now?

Talk about Danny. A ten-year-old with a brass key on a shoelace prayed the whole way down the mountain while his big sister was too proud to. Who is the Danny in your house or your church, the one whose plain, loud faith shames you a little and leads you a lot? Thank God for them this week. Tell them, if you can.

Talk about the green mountain. The dead mountain above Palmerton came back. It took twenty years of seed and lime and patient work, and now people walk it with their dogs and never know it was bare. What in your life looks dead right now? Do you believe the God who held the snow can bring it back the slow way too?

Try this, this week. Read 2 Kings 20:8-11, Joshua 10:12-14, 2 Kings 6:15-17, Hebrews 1:14, and Philippians 2:12-13 out loud, slow, with a pencil in your hand. In the margin write THE LAW TELLS ME WHAT IS NORMAL. Under it write GOD IS NOT LOCKED OUT. Then find the one frozen lever in your week, the thing you have been praying about and not touching. Breathe on it. Put your hands on it. Ask out loud for the time and the strength you need, plain and short like Annie did, and then lift with your legs and your back. If the snow stops for you, keep that one close. If it does not, throw the lever anyway. Either way, you will not be throwing it alone.

Works Cited

Lennox, John C. *Can Science Explain Everything?* The Good Book Company, 2019.